

Episode 93: Once Upon a Time... (56) – *COO* How to Make Colour Direction Sheets Part 1

The other day I received the Blu-ray version of *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!* and watched it at home immediately.

Wow, Blu-ray is too clear... or rather, shows too much (sweat).

The colours and textures were reproduced very vividly, which was perfectly fine in that regard, but everything was visible so clearly down to the smallest details that parts I secretly wanted to gloss over were clearly exposed (heavy sweat).

Blu-ray is dangerous.

While *Casshern Sins* was a TV work, it was broadcast on digital terrestrial, and we approached screen creation from the beginning assuming Blu-ray release, but this *Japan Explodes!!* was originally created with theatrical film projection in mind. While it's a movie shown on large screens, given the film projection format and conditions, the image naturally appears somewhat softer, so considering that, I thought "this should be fine" when creating various scenes (←not cutting corners!).

But showing it on screens that are too crystal clear - honestly, it was heavy sweat material.

Recently TVs themselves are gradually becoming liquid crystal high-definition, plus Blu-ray, so we really need to be careful and consider what final format things will take!

Now then.

I think I wrote this before (←did I write it? (sweat)), but the "colour" work flow is roughly like this:

1. Listen to the director about the overall work concept and keep "roughly like this" in mind.
2. Make trial colour samples for cels based on character settings from the character designer.
3. Check colour samples with director and main staff. Decide basic character colours for the work.
4. Create colouring settings (called "colour direction sheets," "colour direction tables," various names) based on decided colours.
5. Based on storyboards, meet with director and art staff about entire content.
6. Create (modify) colour samples matching art boards for each scene like evening, night, etc., deciding scene-by-scene character colours.
7. Also create colouring settings for scene-specific colour direction (special colouring).
8. Do colour direction for each cut (in-betweens, key animation) in the main episode.
9. Inspect finished colouring, hand over to photography.
10. Rush check of photography results. Issue retakes.
11. Handle retake cuts and continue rush checking. Attend almost to the end.
12. Completion, delivery, happily ever after (sometimes wrap parties).

Most works follow roughly this flow. Between these steps, meetings about individual cut processing and test work + checking for decisions repeat, gradually making various cuts concrete into screens.

Coo: Far From Home work began moving seriously. Key animation gradually started coming up, in-between work, and cuts finally started going to finishing. Which meant soon we needed to do colour direction and send to colouring, but for that we needed to create something first. Yes, creating settings for colouring work, the blueprint for colouring work - "colour direction sheets."

Creating "colours" and "deciding colours" is important work, but creating these "colour direction sheets" is also an important point in "colour" work.

The cuts we colour direct are painted by finishing colouring staff, but specifying paint numbers for every detail in actual cut artwork is impossible. It's time-consuming and becomes very hard to read. So for characters appearing in many cuts with setting artwork, we create colouring settings called "colour direction sheets" in advance and give them to colouring staff to paint based on those. Creating these is also our job as colour design and colour direction staff.

Even today with digital colouring, we create this work as digital data. Since colouring work is done on computers, colours can be picked from colour direction data with tools and placed directly on screen - that's it. Moving images are completed with exactly the colour direction data colours.

But during cel colouring back then, we instructed this only with paint colour numbers on paper settings, and colouring staff would keep these settings in mind or constantly reference them while applying paint to cels.

How we created such colouring settings "colour direction sheets."

First, prepare copies of character setting artwork. At Toei, most works had character masters drawn in B4 size, so we made colour direction sheets in the same 100% copy B4 size.

We'd write paint numbers on these setting sheets, but depending on the setting, there might be parts not drawn from certain angles, or detail explanations in close-up sizes might be separated into different settings, often split across several sheets. If we made colour direction sheets using original settings as-is, colouring one character would require checking 2-3 colour direction sheets. That would be very inconvenient for colorists.

During colouring work, one hand holds a brush, the other a small paint bottle - both hands are basically always occupied, so flipping through colour direction sheet pages in that situation is very troublesome. Usually they'd post current character colour direction sheets around their colouring desk for reference while painting, but space for posting 2-3 sheets is limited, and needing to check 2-3 sheets is inherently troublesome - too much trouble increases accidents like painting mistakes.

So we considered making colour direction sheets as readable as possible on one sheet.

We'd cut apart copies of multi-sheet settings, separating each drawn character and part. Then select angles and parts that fulfilled necessary information for colour direction.

For human character settings, we typically needed: full body front, full body back, sometimes side view, close-up face, and close-up eyes.

We'd re-layout these to fit on B4 size. We'd use copy machine functions to reduce or enlarge parts as needed. This way, we'd recreate one sheet where you could understand that character's colour overview at a glance.

Naturally, case-by-case, sometimes it's more readable not to force everything onto one sheet, so in such cases it's important to organise without forcing it too much.

We'd take clean copies of the cut-and-pasted re-layouts. Finally, we'd add paint numbers and painting division instructions.

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